

## Flight

I keep telling myself that could have gone worse. According to the governing Convocation, my teaching no longer aligns with their stated "truth". I can't roll my eyes on paper, but I am surprised with the speed at which my so-called peers have disavowed themselves of my name. I never took those wizened fools in charge for bold, but to come home to a scoured sanctum, that was a shock. Naturally all my research, having been conducted under their auspices, remains property of The Conservatory. Confiscated. But taking my journals was just plain rude, and that slight shall be returned with delicious irony because they have set *me* free of their supervision.

Starting over is an opportunity. For all their age and wisdom the Convocation is not reckless enough to confront me personally, and the raid on my sanctum allowed me just enough time to react and pivot. With the bargain struck for my admittance to those esteemed wizard's halls now null and void, I am no longer tied to their sight. Now I can freely reengage with my earlier training, and my late master's proclivity for magical contingencies. Thanks to her paranoia, I now find myself the free and legal owner of one stout tower in an unassuming hollow of ash trees, on the front lines of the war, too far from power for their proud eyes to look for me.

Steal my notes, destroy my laboratory, disgrace my name. All these acts will fade with time and it is the amateur arcanist who writes down their best ideas, at least not in ink readable on stolen pages. Thanks to The Conservatory's gracious library policies I have already copied the necessary spells and rituals for my next pursuits; and, regardless of what they say publicly, plenty of those conservatory dolts own owe me enough to call in a favor. (especially after some forceful persuasion, which I am now free to do!) Yes, the reputation of a disgraced academic suits my purposes just fine. By the time I rebuild they will see me as a simple ugly necessity needed to keep the hated Merlings at bay. Ha! Bay.